

Ryan voice locked. Six-position Lotus Syndicate ambush at 02:14 on a wet West Town cross-street, calibrated for *alive but damaged*. Pure cool through every action beat — the geometry, the seam on KT's chrome, the sedan-hop over the quadruped's jaw emitter, the six-second moon-clip reload, the fire-escape slug through Nines' wrist brace, the inside-thigh cut on Rook's flesh-compatible Tier 3 chrome, KT's throat. Then the interview reveal: it was an audition. Sable was always Lotus's fixer. Narrator parentheticals frame the corporate-history-as-comedy (KT's arm subsidy schedule, Hydraulic Solutions recalls, Lotus' Tier 3 "flesh compatible" marketing) but NEVER inside the action. The action is the cool. Long-con seed continues: the avatar hypothesis is the leash, the Lotus pipeline is the actual hostile route.

The Interview

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Part I — The Geometry

The NeoCortex catalogued it at 02:14:33.

Six positions. Half a second. Clean geometry. Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister was walking home through a West Town cross-street that the corporations had agreed, simultaneously and without coordinating about it, neither to maintain nor to surveil, which was the precise condition under which the cross-street had become useful to people who wanted to do specific things at 02:14 on a wet Wednesday in March, and the cross-street tonight was being used.

One position elevated on the fire escape above the panel van. The rifle's barrel found the angle through the grating with a calmness that read as professional rather than confident. One behind the van itself, the electromagnetic signature of augmented limbs bleeding through the chassis like a second heartbeat. One behind the concrete planter at the eastern corner, the dead tree throwing no shadow worth using, the operator's breathing controlled in the way that took years to learn and cost more than years to maintain. One at the parking structure mouth — augmented legs, dense chest plating, the kind of layered armor that said someone had spent real money to make this person hard to stop. One flanker behind him, unaugmented, which meant either they were confident or they were bait. And one non-organic quadruped near the dumpster, pit-bull-sized, jaw emitter cycling at low draw, no BCI signal at all.

(A note on the quadruped, which the array catalogued by signature as a Carrion Logistics LLC field model — yes, that Carrion Logistics LLC — repurposed from body-pickup duty for combat. Carrion Logistics LLC manufactured their quadrupeds in a single contract plant outside Detroit and sold the older units back to the gray market when the new units came in, on a five-year refresh cycle that had, over the past decade, populated the Gray Zone's secondary security market with several thousand decommissioned body-pickup chassis whose stun-jaw emitters had been retrofitted by various aftermarket vendors with varying degrees of legality and competence. The Lotus Syndicate had been a major buyer at the 2222

refresh. The quadruped in the alley tonight was a 2218 unit on a 2222 retrofit. The retrofit had been done by a vendor in Bridgeport who had charged Lotus a flat fee per chassis and who had cut corners on the cooling system in the way you cut corners when the fee is flat. This was going to be relevant in approximately ninety seconds.)

Kyle's bike was three blocks west, parked behind the pharmacy on Ohio, plate covered. He had ridden it down from West Town and walked the last six blocks on foot because the cross-street he was about to engage in was a corridor and bikes did not do well in corridors. He had assumed, sometime around the fourth block, that he might end this evening on foot. He had assumed correctly.

He gave them ten more steps.

The wet asphalt held the streetlight in long orange ribbons and he watched his own reflection walk through them — the katana a dark vertical line against his coat, Chorus riding his left hip. The towers above the cross-street leaned inward at this elevation. The canyon between them framed a strip of sky the rain was falling through, and the strip was, by his rough estimate, just wide enough for a single VTOL to thread through if a VTOL had any business being this far down, which they didn't. The space above the alley was dark. The light came up from the windows, not down from the sky, and the windows here were mostly out.

(There is a particular geometry to a Gray Zone street at 02:14 on a Wednesday in March that does not appear in the corporation real-estate ledgers. The ledgers describe the cross-street as a corridor between two residential blocks. The geometry describes it as a place. A place has occupants. A place has, at this hour, six occupants positioned for ambush and one occupant walking through them, and the place itself knows what it is in the way places that have been used this way before know what they are. The streetlight knows. The wet asphalt knows. The fire escape, which has been the fire escape it was tonight in seven prior engagements going back to 2218, definitely knows. The cross-street had a body count of thirty-one before tonight. Tonight will bring it to thirty-five, conservatively, depending on whether the man on the fire escape gets to a tourniquet in

time. None of these facts are in the corporation ledger. The ledger does not have a column for them.)

The flanker behind him was breathing through his nose, which meant he wasn't scared, which meant he hadn't done this many times or had done it so many times it no longer registered as the kind of event that required fear. Kyle filed that.

He filed the spacing. The six positions triangulated into a containment pattern he had seen before, or almost seen, something at the edge of the catalogue that had been sitting unresolved for two months since a Bucktown engagement where the opposing crew's restraint pattern had matched something he couldn't name. They had let him leave that night. He had not resolved why. The NeoCortex had flagged it and he had filed it under *unresolved* and left it there because filing it under *threat* would have required action and he had not been ready to take action, and that was the truth of it, the specific cowardice that lived in the gap between his code and his capacity, and he had been carrying it quietly, as a fact he hadn't yet decided what to do about.

They committed on the eighth step.

The quadruped cleared the dumpster first — fast and low, the jaw emitter cycling up from idle to active draw in the three-quarters of a second it took to cross the gap, and the sound it made was a grinding cacophony of electromagnetic intent. The fire escape operator dropped into position. The panel van operator stepped into the street with the unhurried confidence of someone who had been told the geometry was already settled. The planter operator stood. The armor at the parking structure mouth did not move at all, which was worse than if it had moved, because stillness at that position meant it was the *door* — not the attack but the seal — and Kyle understood, in the 0.3-second window the NeoCortex gave him before Ballistic Precognition shifted from passive to active, that this had never been an ambush in the way he understood ambushes.

They need me breathing.

The bio-battery read seventy-two percent. The rain was cold against the back of his neck. Five chambers in Chorus — four buckshot moon-clip, one slug seated in the top chamber because he had loaded it that way on the off chance he encountered the kind of door tonight a slug would solve. Six positions in front of him. One question he had been refusing to ask for two months. The quadruped's jaw emitter fully cycled now, and the flanker behind him had stopped breathing through his nose.

Part II — Now

"Now."

The voice came from behind the planter.

Female. Captain register. The kind of voice that was used to other people doing what it said inside a quarter-second of saying it.

Kyle was already moving — not away, *through* — the draw completing itself in the space between her word and the rain hitting his right shoulder as the blade came over it. Silence cleared the saya in one continuous motion. No flourish. No signal. The kawagane caught the orange streetlight only at the edge where the edge always caught light. The corundum strop on his inner left forearm did its work on the way out: a crisp high-frequency stress pulse that the PZT shingane harvested and the blade came out at baseline charge, and the gesture, to anyone watching from anywhere on this cross-street, read as a corrupted chiburi done at the wrong end of the cut, which was the appearance Seo had designed it to wear.

(Tonight, none of the six were watching for the corrupted chiburi. None of the six had been briefed on Silence the way the boss at the loading dock had been briefed. The Lotus Syndicate's intelligence on Kyle's blade was operationally accurate — *carbon nanotube, piezoelectric core, do not engage edge-to-edge* — and operationally incomplete in ways that were going to cost them in approximately fifteen seconds. The literature they had read was a different literature than the literature the boss had read. It was, however, the same kind of literature, by which I mean: incorrect in the specific way that purchased literature was always incorrect about weapons the literature had not personally been cut by.)

The woman stepped from behind the planter.

BCI at the left temple. Close-cropped hair. Machine pistol indexed high. Lotus south-arm, captain grade, the kind of woman who ran containment because she trusted the geometry.

He did not catalogue her name.

He would learn the name in roughly five minutes, when she gave it to him along with the rest of the evening's actual purpose. For now she was *captain, planter, machine pistol, calling it*, and the blade was already moving toward the chrome arm coming at him from his right.

KT was faster than the arm.

(KT — Kira Tanaka, twenty-eight, Lotus south-arm fourteen months, Tier 2 chrome prosthetic right arm installed under the Syndicate's freelance-to-fulltime advancement subsidy in 2225 at the Bridgeport clinic Lotus used for that class of upgrade. The subsidy carried a 4.2% interest rate amortized over five years, payable in monthly installments deducted from her contract earnings. The arm was therefore, at the time of tonight's engagement, fourteen months into a sixty-month note. KT did not own the arm yet. The arm was the working capital of her employment with Lotus. The arm had cost twenty-three thousand QUANTA at install. KT had paid back approximately fifty-four hundred. The arm had four years and ten months of payments remaining. None of this is operationally relevant. It is mentioned here because in approximately eight seconds Kyle is going to take the arm out of service permanently, and the arm has had a life of its own, and the life of the arm deserves to be on the page even if the life of the arm is about to end. KT, for her part, will outlive the arm by about thirty seconds. The arm will outlive the engagement by about three minutes. The Bridgeport clinic will write off the remaining balance on Lotus's books in the morning.)

The chrome came out elbow-to-fingertip in a full extension that telegraphed the angle. Kyle read the machete in her unaugmented right before she committed to the swing. He dropped his shoulder and the blade passed the air where his neck had been, and he turned the geometry into his — Silence coming across low and redirecting the prosthetic's mass rather than meeting it, the edge scoring chrome instead of flesh, because he needed her functional for the next four seconds and because the arm wasn't hers, not really, and that mattered to some part of him that wasn't the hardware.

She staggered.

He stepped past her toward the van.

The flanker — name not yet learned, designation *Dex* if anyone on the street was using designations, which they weren't — closed from behind. Unaugmented. Both handguns drawn. The breathing he had catalogued as *controlled* rather than *afraid*. The NeoCortex tracked him at the edge of the predictive window, seven degrees outside the primary engagement cone, which meant Dex was the variable the formation was counting on.

The armor at the structure mouth — designation *Rook* — hadn't moved from the seal position. The rifle on the fire escape — designation *Nines* — had the angle, but had not fired. Which meant the order was still *alive*, which meant Kyle had exactly as long as it took someone to decide the geometry was no longer worth the constraint.

The quadruped rounded the van at low profile, jaw emitter at full draw now, the pre-sound filling the wet air with something between pressure and intent.

He kept moving.

Part III — The Seam

KT's arm came horizontal and he did not step back.

He stepped *into* it.

Not to meet it. To find the angle the arm could not intercept.

Silence came up not to her chrome but to the shoulder seam where the chrome socket met flesh — the same seam Kyle had found on a chrome-arm man at a Gray Zone loading dock several years ago, the same seam every shop-grade chrome arm presented in a slot of unprotected actuator housing roughly a thumb-width wide. The edge passed through the gap the way the edge passed through anything when the angle was right and the line was committed. Bone, tendon, the cable bundle that carried the motor bus from the spinal interface — Silence did not care about any of it because Silence was a sword and what swords cared about was the geometry of where the edge met the body, and the geometry was correct.

Tink.

KT's chrome arm did not fall off.

The arm did not need to fall off. The arm needed to stop receiving signals. The motor bus was severed. The arm hung dead from the shoulder, hydraulics holding it in approximate position but no longer responding to anything KT was telling it to do. She made a sound that was less than screaming and more than nothing — the involuntary exhalation of a body that had just lost a limb it had been counting on, the specific noise of *circuit breaker tripping* that Kyle had heard before and would hear again because shop-grade chrome was always going to surrender the seam to anyone who knew where to look.

He stepped past her.

The captain's burst from the planter was controlled. Two rounds, tight grouping, the machine pistol indexed exactly where he had been standing

0.4 seconds ago. He read the muzzle before the report and stepped left. The rounds clipped the car door behind him, the metallic percussion of rounds punching sheet metal. He catalogued the angle. He catalogued that she fired at all, which meant the geometry had shifted faster than she expected, which meant the formation's tolerance for *alive but damaged* had just compressed.

He also catalogued that her call to Nines arrived late.

He heard it. Two words, clipped, the cadence of someone issuing an order that should already have been issued. The rifle on the fire escape did not fire when the angle opened. The angle opened cleanly. Nines had the shot. Nines did not take it.

(The latency between the captain's call and Nines's non-firing was 0.31 seconds. The NeoCortex flagged it. Kyle filed it under *Bucktown*, same drawer, same heading: *capability without permission*. He did not resolve it. He kept moving.)

The quadruped's jaw emitter was fully drawn behind him now. He could feel the air pressure on the back of his neck — the inductive pulse building toward discharge — and the legs cadence shifted as the rear actuators loaded for the lunge.

He went up.

Left boot on the sedan's hood. Right boot finding the windshield frame.

The jaw emitter discharged into the air under his boot sole with a sound like a circuit board clearing itself, the inductive pulse arcing through empty space because there was nothing under it to deliver to.

Pop. Sccrrrk.

(The pulse was throttled. The pulse should not have been throttled. A real combat drone would have stacked the discharge — would have hit the nerve bundles in his calf and let the cascade do the rest. This one passed at exactly the level that registered as a near-miss and continued cycling, and Kyle

catalogued the throttle the way you catalogued a piece of evidence that did not fit the working theory: visibly, and then quietly. The Bucktown crew had held back the same way. Two months of *unresolved* and the catalogue closed the file now, quietly, without ceremony: *they need the product undamaged*. He did not act on it. The hardware filed. The man kept moving.)

He dropped Chorus into his left hand on the way down off the hood. Bird's-head grip. The recurve handle seating itself the way a handle only seated when it had been fitted to the hand that held it. Thumb the hammer back on the slug chamber that had been waiting in the top position since he loaded it that afternoon. First round through the rear actuator housing as he came off the hood.

Crack.

The legs collapsed.

The dog dragged itself forward on its front pair, jaw still cycling, the threat halved and still present.

He stepped past it because *halved* was enough.

Part IV — Rook

Rook fired at three meters.

Kyle read the shoulders before the trigger broke — the left shoulder pulling back fractionally, the way a man pulled back when he was trying to account for movement he expected — and stepped the angle. The round passed through the space between his right arm and his ribs with a percussion he felt in his teeth but not in his side. The NeoCortex registered *wound: none*.

The four buckshot chambers in Chorus's cylinder were still loaded. Slug chamber empty. The cylinder indexed the next chamber on the next pull. Rook was already adjusting his grip for the second shot and Kyle was already inside the correction.

(Rook — Erik Rooker, thirty-six, Lotus south-arm seven years, Tier 3 augmented legs installed in 2222 at a Hong Kong clinic that did not advertise its services to anyone outside Lotus's preferred-vendor network. Rook had not financed his legs. The legs had been gifted by Lotus on his promotion to fixed-position security. The legs were therefore Lotus property in the way most things in Rook's life were Lotus property, which was the kind of arrangement Tier 3 augmentation had specialized in creating since the technology's commercial introduction in 2218. Tier 3 chrome was advertised by every corporation that sold it as *flesh-compatible*, which was true at the level of the marketing copy and false at the level of the femoral artery. The corporations had calculated, accurately, that flesh-compatibility was a feature their customers would pay for. The customers had not asked which flesh. The femoral was flesh. The customers had not been told the femoral was the price.)

The Augmentation Signature Read had had Rook mapped since the parking structure. Augmented legs, Tier 3, interface points at both hips, BCI at the right temple, no cardiac. Kyle did not need the chrome to fail.

The chrome would keep working until the man inside it stopped working.

The man inside it had a femoral artery on the inside of each augmented leg where the prosthetic's intake bonded to the original tissue. Tier 3 chrome had left the major vessels intact because Tier 3 chrome was *flesh-compatible*.

Kyle took the last two steps inside the barrel.

The slide pressed against his ribs as Rook fired, the round going into concrete below his foot, the muzzle blast burning through his shirt in a clean circle that he would find tomorrow and understand as the measurement of how close he had cut it. He did not catalogue the burn. He catalogued the inside of Rook's left thigh.

Silence came in a precise arc — low, angled inward, the cut traveling across the interior of the thigh at the line the femoral followed below the chrome intake.

The edge passed through the gap the way the edge always passed through gaps.

Rook's left leg, which had been bearing his weight in firing stance, did not collapse from the cut — Tier 3 chrome did not need blood to function — but Rook himself did, because the cut had opened the femoral and Rook had between forty and ninety seconds depending on which textbook you trusted, and Kyle did not need ninety. Rook's eyes did not go blank. They went confused. His augmented legs were still trying to hold him. His body was no longer cooperating with the augmentation. He sat down on the concrete the way a building settles — not falling, just descending to the level gravity had been recommending all along. The pistol dropped from a hand that had become uncertain about what it was holding. He looked at the leg. He looked at Kyle. He breathed.

The chrome was not the problem. The chrome had been advertised, accurately, as flesh-compatible. And the flesh was the part Kyle had asked for.

Rook bled out at the curb in just over a minute.

Kyle did not stay for it.

He stepped past him.

He turned from the structure entrance.

Part V — KT

KT came around the planter at a sprint and she was screaming something that used to be words.

The dead arm swung useless at her left side, the chrome catching the orange streetlight in a way that made it look decorative, a trophy she was carrying rather than a limb. The machete was overhead, both-handed grip because she had one hand that worked.

Kyle read the arc before she committed to it — the shoulder angle, the lean, the way a person ran when they had already decided the outcome and were simply delivering the body to the decision. He stepped inside. Not back, not sideways, *inside*, into the space the arc could not reach.

Silence moved the way it moved when he was not thinking about it, which was the way it moved best.

The edge found her throat at the closest point.

The cut was clean.

(The kind of clean the people who built him would have liked.)

The thought arrived in his own voice. He filed it where he filed those thoughts — not deep, not hidden, just set aside in the way you set aside something you were not going to examine tonight.)

The blade carried through the full motion and rang off the concrete planter on the follow-through — a hard clean note in the wet air, steel on stone, the kind of sound an old katana made when it met an old material at the right angle.

Tang.

KT's machete hit the asphalt.

The sound it made was smaller than it should have been.

Dex, from somewhere behind the van: "He cut KT's head off, man. He just —"

"Shut up."

The captain's voice.

Kyle catalogued the tightness in it.

Not the tightness of a captain whose geometry was failing — he had heard that, knew the cadence of tactical recalculation, the compression that happened when a plan started costing more than projected. This was something else. Something that had a name he did not have access to from this angle, at this distance, with this much blood on the wet asphalt between them.

(KT had been on the captain's cell for fourteen months. The captain had recommended the chrome arm to KT in 2225. The captain had signed off on KT's freelance-to-fulltime advancement on the same Tuesday in 2225 the arm had been installed. The captain had built tonight's six-position ambush around KT's chrome because the captain had wanted to see, specifically, what Kyle would do to chrome the captain had personally invested fourteen months in. The captain had not expected Kyle to take the seam in the way he had taken the seam. The captain had also not expected the throat. The captain's tightness was the tightness of someone who had designed a test and had just learned what the test was actually measuring. The captain's tightness was, in this respect, the most honest sound on the street.)

Kyle did not know any of that yet.

He filed the tightness anyway. He would unfile it in five minutes.

He turned toward the fire escape.

Part VI — Six Seconds

The bandoleer pouch opened on the first thumb-snap — the leather worn to the exact softness that meant it opened without thought, which was why Seo had built it that way.

The fresh moon clip was heavier than the half-spent one in the cylinder. He read the weight with his thumb as he slid it free of the pouch. Five rounds. All slug. Fragmentation tips. The kind of round you carried when you didn't know what you were going to need to put a hole through but you wanted to be sure the hole would be the kind of hole that ended the problem.

He thumbed the cylinder release on Chorus.

The cylinder swung out, the spent slug chamber and four live buckshot chambers exposed in the rain. He turned Chorus barrel-up. The half-spent moon clip dropped into his off-hand by gravity, four buckshot still on the clip, ringing as it dropped because the rain was on the metal and the rain made everything sound clean. He dropped the spent clip into the bandoleer's catch pocket — not the cleanest holster work the discipline had ever asked of him, but the discipline did not have a category for *replace your live ammunition mid-fight to put a fragmentation round through a man three stories up* and Kyle had improvised the category twenty years ago and had not improved it since.

The fresh moon clip went into the cylinder.

He snapped Chorus closed.

He thumbed the hammer back.

The cylinder seated. The action engaged.

Six seconds.

He had practiced six seconds, in dry weather, against a wall in 2F, on evenings when the discipline had asked for something to do besides

cleaning the blade.

(The reload procedure was Seo's design. Seo had not been a revolver man — Seo had been a katana man — but Seo had spent eleven years working with a Chicago-trained gunsmith named Marius who had specialized in moon-clip revolvers for the kind of customer who needed to switch loads quickly under stress. Marius had built Chorus to Seo's specifications in 2218, in a workshop above a hardware store in Wicker that had been demolished in 2222 to make room for an Arcturus parking annex. Marius had died in 2221. The annex had never been built. The lot had remained empty for four years and was, by 2226, weed-grown and serving as the de facto cat colony for that block of Wicker. Cats are sometimes mentioned in passing in this book. The reason they are mentioned in passing in this book is that the cats had inherited Marius's workshop the way cats inherit a great many things, and Kyle, who walked past the lot occasionally, had developed a habit of nodding to the cats, who had developed a habit of nodding back. This is not relevant. It is mentioned because Chorus was made by a man whose workshop the cats inherited, and the inheritance felt to Kyle, when he thought about it at all, like an arrangement Marius would have approved of.)

He raised Chorus toward the fire escape.

Nines was three stories up. In profile. The cybernetic wrist-brace caught the orange streetlight at the inner forearm where the steel showed through the sleeve — the kind of brace that meant nerve damage, old injury, the arm rebuilt around the loss. Kyle put the slug through the brace junction.

Crack.

The explosive fragmentation took the wrist apart the way a sentence ended when the grammar collapsed — not gradually, all at once — and the rifle came off the grating and dropped three stories to the alley below.

Nines went down on the fire escape screaming in the way that meant the arterial bleeder had already started. The kind of bleed that needed a tourniquet inside two minutes or it became a different kind of problem.

Kyle did not climb.

He did not call up.

He did not send the captain, who had the closest angle and the most reason to move.

He knew what he was leaving on that fire escape. He filed it with the other things he was filing tonight — the same drawer, the same quiet act of not examining — and thumbed the hammer back a second time on the next slug in the cylinder.

Dex broke from behind the van and ran south.

Kyle tracked him for 1.4 seconds, the NeoCortex painting the probability cone of the sprint, and then he let the cone collapse. Dex was running in the way that meant he would not stop running tonight, and the things Dex had seen would travel faster than Dex could carry them, and that was already true and could not be made less true by the expenditure of a round Kyle was going to need.

He kept the muzzle low.

The quadruped was dragging itself toward the sedan on its two functioning front legs, jaw emitter still cycling. The captain had not moved from the planter. The night was not finished with him yet.

Part VII — The Dog Again

He dropped off the sedan hood as the quadruped dragged itself the last two meters.

Jaw still cycling. The front actuators grinding wet asphalt. The thing's persistence purely mechanical, no calculation in it, just the forward instruction running until it ran out. He let it close. At one meter he put the second Chorus round through the jaw emitter housing at the angle the NeoCortex gave him — not center-mass, not dramatic, the smallest aperture that ended the problem.

Crack — scccrk.

The stun system died mid-cycle with a sound like a word that didn't finish.

The momentum carried the chassis into his shin anyway.

He stepped over it. Left hand dropped to asphalt as he caught his balance. Palm flat against the wet ground for a fraction of a second. Then rising again.

(The quadruped, dark now at the curb, would be retrieved by Carrion Logistics LLC at approximately 04:30 under their existing service contract with the Lotus Syndicate, alongside the bodies of KT and Rook. The retrieval team would not file a report about the chassis specifically. The chassis would be returned to the Carrion Logistics LLC depot in Englewood and would be added to the recycling backlog. The recycling backlog at the Englewood depot was, as of March 2226, approximately four hundred and seventy chassis deep. The chassis would sit in the backlog until summer 2229, at which point a new contract with a different vendor would change the disposition schedule, and the chassis would be exported intact to a buyer in the Settled Worlds whose interest in decommissioned GLMZ field combat hardware would not be officially disclosed in any record Kyle's array could ever query. This is also not relevant. It is included because the chassis is going to have a longer afterlife than anyone in the engagement

realized, and the longer afterlife is a feature of how the Gray Zone's negative space worked: nothing died, exactly; things were redirected.)

The dog was down near the sedan. The jaw emitter dark. The front actuators still and folded in the particular way that meant the power cell was drained rather than destroyed — it would cycle back if someone reset it, which was a problem for someone who was not Kyle, tonight, in this rain.

Rook was at the curb. Nothing was behind his eyes anymore. The body was doing the body's quiet work of letting the rest of itself follow the blood out.

Kyle looked at the place on the asphalt where KT's machete had landed. The sound it had made when it hit came back to him with the precision the NeoCortex reserved for things it had catalogued as *significant without yet knowing why*.

A machete was not a subtle weapon.

Neither was the arm that had swung it.

Neither was the debt that had bought the arm.

He looked away from the machete and up at the fire escape.

Three stories. The sound Nines was making had changed register — lower now, less urgent, which was the direction sounds went when the body began conserving. Two minutes was an estimate. The NeoCortex did not update it.

He filed Nines in the same drawer where he had been filing things all night.

The drawer was heavier than it had been when the night started.

He did not examine what that weight meant.

He walked toward the captain.

Part VIII — Bucktown

She had not run.

He gave her credit for that the way he gave credit for things that cost something — without warmth, without ceremony, as a fact that belonged in the catalogue. The machine pistol was indexed low and slightly left, which was the indexing of someone who had decided not to use it and had not yet decided what to do with their hands. Her BCI was at the left temple. She was breathing through her nose. The orange streetlight was behind her and it caught the rain on her shoulders and the wet asphalt threw the light back up from below and she looked, for 0.3 seconds, like something the city had built rather than someone who worked for it.

He did not catalogue this.

He let it pass.

The blade was in his right hand. The night was almost over. Nines was making a sound that was getting quieter.

He walked toward her because she was the only thing left on this street that was still a question.

"Fourteen of us jumped you in the Bucktown stretch two months ago," she said. "You walked out. We lost eight people."

The NeoCortex did not flag the statement as new information. It filed it as *closure* — the label that fit the folder that had been sitting open for two months, the specific cowardice of not asking why the Bucktown crew had let him leave.

He looked at her. He did not show the recognition. He had spent the entire walk over wondering whether she would be the one to name it, and now that she had named it the catalogue was not particularly relieved. The naming had not been the problem. The problem had been the two months of not naming.

"This wasn't a hit." Her voice had something in it that was not the tightness from before. He did not have a word for it. "This was a test. I needed to see if the stories were true."

The NeoCortex flagged the micro-expressions. Brow symmetry. Lip compression. The particular stillness around the eyes that belonged to people who had stopped performing and started saying something.

She was not lying.

He hated that the hardware was the thing that knew this. He would have preferred to know it himself, from the part of him that was not facility-built, but that part did not have the processing speed and tonight the processing speed was the only thing that had been earning its weight.

"They're true," he said.

The machine pistol came up.

He read the shot in the 0.2 seconds before she took it — the shoulder angle, the wrist rotation, the specific indexing of someone firing into a target they had already decided to keep. He did not dodge. The round hit the subdermal mesh at his left shoulder and deformed against the lattice with an impact like a fist from someone who meant it, and the force travelled down through his arm and into the hand that held Silence, and the steel transmitted the shock the way steel transmitted any shock — straight through, into the floor of his palm, into the small joints of his fingers, into the place where his discipline kept its accounts.

He kept walking.

Two meters from her he stopped.

The blade had not moved from low carry.

It was the same matte-black blade it had been at the start of the night and at the end of it, and the rain ran off it the way the rain ran off everything else in this city.

"Drop the weapon," he said.

A half-second where nothing came.

Then her professional register found its footing, and she dropped it.

The machine pistol clattered on the wet asphalt the way every other piece of hardware on this street had clattered tonight.

(The street, by Kyle's rough estimate, was now carrying somewhere north of forty thousand QUANTA of dead and broken cyberware between the dog, KT, Rook, and the rifle that had fallen three stories. The cross-street had not been worth forty thousand QUANTA of anything five minutes ago. The world was, in this small specific way, fucked at exactly the tempo Kyle had ridden in to it on. Carrion Logistics LLC, at this hour, was approximately ninety minutes away from being paid to clean it up.)

Part IX — Lotus Wants You

"Lotus wants you on payroll."

The machine pistol was on the asphalt between them. She did not look at it.

"Full protection envelope. Percentage of every contracted route through our territory. A salary the Pivot would not feel." She said *the Pivot* the way someone said a word they had looked up before they needed it.

The NeoCortex catalogued the research. He did not show that he catalogued it.

"You said no the first time. I'm asking again."

He did not raise the blade. He let the rain do what it was going to do to his face. Above them Nines was making a sound that was almost not a sound anymore. The dog's actuators were still trying to cycle the broken jaw emitter at irregular intervals, the chassis ticking at the curb, the kind of mechanical noise that did not need anyone to listen to it but happened regardless.

"No," he said.

She nodded.

The nod arrived a half-beat after a captain who had expected that answer would have produced it. He filed the half-beat. She did not press.

"Freelance roster, then." Her voice had levelled back into professional register and he gave her credit for the speed of the recovery and nothing else. "Lotus contracts routes through our territory that need a clean face on them. You get first refusal. Carrier rates. No Lotus crew on you in the meantime."

She said *in the meantime* the way people said phrases that were doing more work than they appeared to be doing. He filed that too.

The wet asphalt between them held the orange streetlight in long irregular pools and the rain came down between them at the same indifferent rate it had come down the entire engagement.

The arrangement she was describing lived in this — two people on a cross-street with a dead woman thirty meters behind them and a man above them spending the last of what the bleed had left him. The math was honest. The freelance roster was the smallest concession this night could end with: his independence formally intact, the audition crews kept off him, the fee structure named plainly, no Lotus brand on anything he did or touched or was.

He had spent his life refusing to be anyone's man.

The roster was not that. The roster was a door he could close from the inside.

What the math did not say — what the math could not say because it did not have access to the full dataset — was that the Syndicate had run fourteen people into him two months ago and lost eight of them and had not stopped. Had not stopped.

He filed the gap. He would not examine it tonight.

(The audition had been an audition. The recruitment was the test result. The test result was that he had passed by killing two of the people who had designed the test. Lotus would now compensate him for the two months they had been studying him by hiring him. The world was managed by people who built systems like this and convinced themselves the systems were the only way the work could get done, and Kyle had stopped being the kind of man who argued the point a long time ago. He had become, instead, the kind of man who closed the door from the inside.)

Laugh or you'd cry. Kyle laughed, quietly, into the inside of his collar, where Mira could not see it.

"Fixer's name."

"Sable."

She said it without hesitation, which meant it was ready, which meant the name had always been part of the offer.

He nodded.

The name landed in the place names landed.

He did not show that it landed.

(The name landed in his sternum next to the hum.

The Lotus Syndicate's freelance roster ran through the same fixer whose pipeline he had been working from the cracked terminal at Otto's parts shop for two months. The fixer who had walked him into the Faraday cage four nights ago. The fixer whose tan coat had taken him east through the rain and back. The fixer who had built the avatar hypothesis with him.

Sable.

The pipeline that had been delivering his contracts was also the pipeline that had been delivering Lotus's. The pipeline had not been advertising this. Sable had not been advertising this. The pipeline had been doing two jobs at once, with one face on, and Kyle was now hearing the second face named for the first time.

He filed it.

He would examine it later.

He would examine it carefully.

The drawer for tonight's filings was heavy and the bed in 2F was four blocks away and the captain was still standing in the rain waiting for him to walk away from her so the rest of this could be tomorrow's problem.)

He looked at the dog, chassis dark near the sedan, front actuators folded in the particular stillness of drained power rather than destroyed mechanism.

He looked at Rook, at the curb, with a leg that had not needed to be augmented to be the leg that had killed him. He looked at the place on the asphalt where KT's machete had fallen and made a sound he had still not finished cataloguing, and the blade was in his right hand and Nines on the fire escape was quiet now in a way that had stopped being about the bleed.

He turned.

The wet cross-street opened ahead of him toward The Pivot, toward the cold broth he had not finished at Mrs. Chen's, toward whatever the morning was going to ask of him, and he walked.

Part X — West Erie South

West Erie south.

The towers leaned into the cross-street the way they did at every elevation Kyle moved through GLMZ at — the verticality of the city pressing the rain into vertical columns wherever the air had room to move. At street level the rain was a vertical column of cold percussion through the canyon between The Pivot's block and the residential lattice across from it.

His left shoulder registered the bruise in slow pulses, the subdermal mesh having done what it was built to do, which was stop the round and hand the force to the tissue underneath, which was not built for anything in particular. He catalogued it without examining it.

The rain had thinned to mist and the mist caught the streetlight in ways that were not interesting and he was grateful for that.

The bike was still where he had left it behind the pharmacy on Ohio. He walked past the alley on his way north, not stopping. He had walked into the cross-street tonight and he would walk out of it. The bike was for the morning. The morning was the morning. The discipline did not have a category for *ride home after killing two people who arranged a six-position ambush to recruit you*, and Kyle had decided, somewhere in the last block, that the discipline was correct not to have one.

Mrs. Chen's stall was dark.

The fold-down counter was latched. The small propane burner under the left unit was cold — he knew this from three feet away because he knew the smell of it running and this was not that smell. She opened at four. He had two hours on her.

He walked past and did not slow down and did not look at the counter where the broth he had not finished was not waiting for him.

(He had thought about the broth twice since the night had started. Both times he had filed it somewhere practical and both times it had come back. This was the third time. He did not file it again. He let it sit in the part of him that was not the hardware and kept walking. She had made it too hot so that he would have to stay. He had stood up anyway. The discipline had been the discipline. The broth had been the broth. He would buy another bowl at 16:30, and the bowl would be hot, and she would not mention the one he had not finished, and this was the way the arrangement worked — by editorial restraint on both sides, by the discipline of not naming the thing the discipline had asked you to do.)

The Pivot was four blocks. The bio-battery read fifty-eight percent and cooling. The NeoCortex was running at its ceiling and had been for twenty minutes and he knew what that meant the way you knew what a soft tire meant, which was that it meant something and tonight was not the night to examine what.

He climbed the stairs to 2F.

The third step from the top made its sound.

Pixel's sleep-suppression protocol came through the wall at 2E the way her music came through the wall — not loud, not intrusive, present. He read the hardware signature without meaning to. BCI at reduced draw, the specific rhythm of a protocol that was managing something rather than ending it, the kind of running-state that meant her nights were not quiet enough to sleep through unaided.

(He had known this for months. He had filed it the way he filed exits — not because he planned to use it, because knowing where the exits were was what he did. Pixel had been taking the sleep-suppression protocol since 2225, by Kyle's best estimate, and the protocol was, on the open market, prescribed for a class of conditions Pixel did not discuss with Kyle and which Kyle did not bring up because the not-bringing-up was the discipline. The protocol was running tonight. The protocol had been running for fourteen months. Kyle did not, at this hour, know what Pixel was managing. He suspected he would, eventually. He had decided, some weeks ago, that the eventual knowing was going to be in Pixel's time, not his.)

He sat on the edge of the bed.

Silence went across his thighs in the saya. His right hand held the hilt because it was where his hand went when the night was over and he was not yet sure the night was over.

The blade was cold against his thigh through the saya, which was the only thing the blade was ever doing when the blade was not cutting anything, which was the part of the discipline he had not, when he was nineteen, expected to find comforting.

(He had been wrong, at nineteen, about most of the things he had been certain of. The blade being just a sword had been one of them.)

The shoulder ached in the slow specific way that would be worse tomorrow.

The deal sat in the room with him and he did not examine it and it did not leave.

Sable was the fixer.

Sable had been the fixer for two months.

Sable was now also Lotus's fixer, or had been from the beginning, and the difference between those two readings was the work he was not going to do tonight.

The drawer was heavy.

The morning was four hours away.

The bird upstairs in 3F was doing something with the building's HVAC that Pixel had catalogued as epistemological field-work and Kyle had catalogued as ambient noise, and the bird worked overnight the way Pixel worked overnight, and they were each other's companions in a building Kyle now realized he had been living in for four years and which he had stopped, somewhere in the second year, being able to imagine leaving.

He did not sleep.

He held the blade across his thighs and listened to the rain and watched the slow gray light start to push at the bottom edge of the window, and the world was still fucked, and tomorrow was still going to be its own day, and the deal sat in the room with him until the slow gray light became the kind of light he could pretend was morning.

He stood up.

(Pixel did not open her door tonight. The protocol was running and the protocol was the protocol. Tomorrow she would open the door. Tomorrow he would let her see what the shoulder looked like. Tomorrow she would file a fragment that was not a fragment because the round had not made it through the subdermal mesh, but she would file the bruise as if it were a fragment because the convention required something to be filed. Tomorrow the convention would do its work. Tonight the convention had decided to sleep through it, and Kyle, who had been refusing to be anyone's man for as long as he could remember, was grateful for the discipline of editorial restraint that had not, in two months, ever yet asked him to explain.

This too will be more fully explored at a later time.

For now: the gray light. The window. The morning the morning.)

He stood up.

(And so did the city. The city always did. The cross-street, by 04:47, was clean — Carrion Logistics LLC had been efficient, the bodies were on the schedule, the hardware was in the recycling backlog, the wet asphalt was rinsing the last of the blood into the gutter at the precise rate the rain had been engineered to produce. By the time Mrs. Chen opened the stall at 04:00, there was nothing on the cross-street to suggest the cross-street had been the cross-street it had been at 02:14, except for a small notch in the concrete planter where the edge of an old katana had rung on stone. The notch would still be there in twenty years. The city would not, by then, remember which engagement had put it there. Mrs. Chen would not know to look. Sable, of course, would. Sable knew most things. Carry on.)